Weekly Bulletin of IT News and Articles

(7 January 2026 – 13 January 2026)

Department of Strategy and Analysis
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Calendar of Upcoming events

Upcoming IT Events					
№	Event Name	Date	Location	Description	Official Website
1.	**Future Technologies Forum**	Feb 26–27, 2026	Moscow, Russia	A major forum on advanced computing, quantum technologies, and data economy. Often attended by top government officials.	https://future-forum.tech/
2.	**Web Summit Qatar 2026**	Feb 1–4, 2026	Doha, Qatar	**Regional Hub.** While in Qatar, this is a primary destination for CIS/Central Asian startups and ministries seeking Middle East partnerships.	https://qatar.websummit.com/
3.	**MWC Barcelona**	Mar 2–5, 2026	Barcelona, Spain	The world's largest connectivity event. While in Spain, it is the key annual meeting point for all CIS & OTS telecom ministers and major telcos.	https://www.mwcbarcelona.com/
4.	**WcCST-2026**	Mar 26–27, 2026	Chandigarh, India	**Scientific/Academic.** World Conference on Computational Science & Technology. A major destination for CIS academic delegations and AI researchers.	https://www.cuchd.in/conference/WcCST-26/
5.	**Central Eurasian Venture Forum (CEVF)**	Apr 3, 2026	Tashkent, Uzbekistan	**Major Investment Event.** For the first time moving to Tashkent. The region's premier event for VCs, startups, and tech investors.	https://ventureforum.asia/
6.	**GITEX Africa 2026**	Apr 7–9, 2026	Marrakech, Morocco	**Emerging Markets.** Increasingly popular for CIS IT exporters looking for new markets in Africa.	https://gitexafrica.com/
7.	**LEAP 2026**	Apr 13–16, 2026	Riyadh, Saudi Arabia	**Global Mega-Event.** A critical strategic meeting point for Central Asian Digital Ministers *(Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan usually send large delegations).*	https://onegiantleap.com/
8.	**TIBO 2026**	Apr 28–30, 2026	Minsk, Belarus	33rd International Forum on Telecommunications, Information and Banking Technologies. The main IT event in Belarus.	https://tibo.by/

CIS NEWS

1. IT sector included in types of activities for reduced insurance tariffs in Russia

(Official publication of legal acts)

Код в соответствии с Общероссийским классификатором видов экономической деятельности ОК 029-2014	Наименование группировки
	и прочих услуг, связанных с удалением отходов
50	Деятельность водного транспорта
51	Деятельность воздушного и космического транспорта
53	Деятельность почтовой связи и курьерская деятельность
55	Деятельность по предоставлению мест для временного проживания
56	Деятельность по предоставлению продуктов питания и напитков
58	Деятельность издательская
59	Производство кинофильмов, видеофильмов и телевизионных программ, издание звукозаписей и нот
60	Деятельность в области телевизионного и радиовещания
61	Деятельность в сфере телекоммуникаций
62	Разработка компьютерного программного обеспечения, консультационные услуги в данной области и другие сопутствующие услуги
63	Деятельность в области информационных технологий
68.3	Операции с недвижимым имуществом за вознаграждение или на договорной основе
72	Научные исследования и разработки
74	Деятельность профессиональная научная и техническая прочая

Russia's **Prime Minister Mikhail Mishustin** has approved a government directive *(enforceable from 1 Jan 2026)* containing a list of economic activities for reduced insurance premiums. The inventory includes ICT area. In particular:

- production of computers, electronic and optical products;

- telecommunications activities;

- development of computer software, consulting services in this area and other related services;

- activities in the field of information technology;

- repair of computers, personal items and household purposes.

The benefit applies if the corresponding type of economic activity is indicated as the main type of activity of the company, and if, in accordance with outcomes of the reporting period, the amount of all income of at least 70 % is income from the implementation of the main type of economic activity.

(Read full document at http://publication.pravo.gov.ru/document/0001202512290075)

2. Kazakh government rules out AI deputy ministers

(The Times of Central Asia)

AI will not be occupying senior government posts in Kazakhstan anytime soon. While AI-based tools may serve as advisors and consultants to top officials, there are currently no plans to appoint virtual or digital deputy ministers. **Rostislav Konyashkin**, First Deputy Minister of Artificial Intelligence and Digital Development, said in a statement at a press conference following a cabinet meeting, when journalists referenced Albania's 2025 decision to appoint a virtual minister for public

procurement, the first of its kind globally. They asked whether Kazakhstan was considering a similar initiative.

According to **Konyashkin**, AI systems have not yet reached the level of reliability required for managing official functions.

"As political officials, we are responsible for the decisions we make, so the emergence of digital deputy ministers is not expected at this time. When AI provides correct answers in 95-97 % of cases, then perhaps we can begin discussing the transfer of some powers to algorithms. For now, we are only talking about AI assisting in analysis and decision-making," he stated.

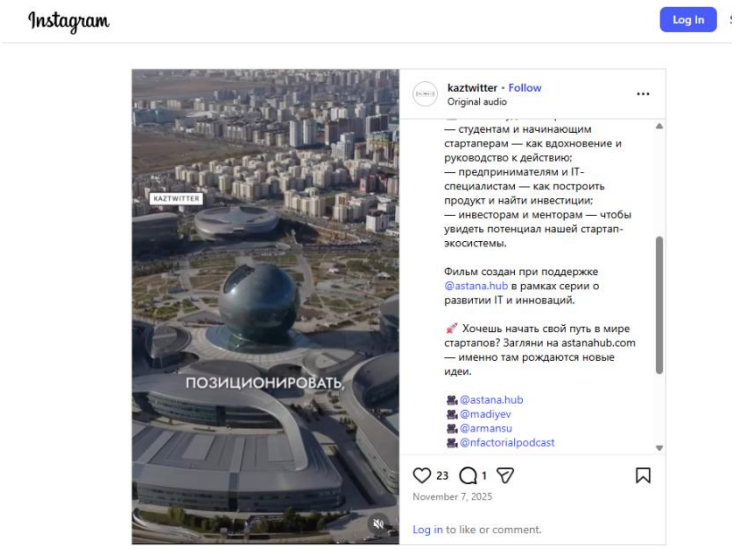
(Read full article at https://timesca.com/kazakh-government-rules-out-ai-deputy-ministers/)

3. A documentary seeks to promote Astana Hub startup ecosystem

(KazTwitter Instagram account)

Kazakhstan's Astana Hub is in spotlight in Instagram: a documentary posted once again on the social network *(it was initially posted on 7 Nov 2025)* sheds light on the IT and startup ecosystem underway in the country.

The film describes a usual route from the idea to the international market whereby young innovators and entrepreneurs go through the path of first pitches, accelerators, crises, and investments. *"They are the stories of people who create the future of Kazakhstan through technology and perseverance"*, reads the trailer to the video.



The film is designed for students and beginners as inspiration and guidance for action; entrepreneurs and IT specialists – for how to build a product and find investments; investors and mentors – to see the potential of the startup ecosystem.

(Watch the film on https://www.instagram.com/reel/DQwcAzpDVUy/?utm_source)

4. Dushanbe teen develops Tajikistan's first AI legal assistant

(The Times of Central Asia)

Tajikistan has launched its first AI-powered legal assistant designed to simplify access to legal information by explaining laws in plain language. The project, called Moni, was developed by 15-year-old **Foteh Azizov** from Dushanbe. Already, the platform is being used not only by the general public, but also by practicing lawyers.

Azizov said the idea for Moni came from his own experience. While helping with content and promotion at his uncle's law firm, he noticed how difficult it was for ordinary people and even himself to understand the complex language used in legal documents.

"Laws are often written in a complicated style, full of terminology," Azizov explained. "That's when I came up with the idea of creating a tool that explains the law in simple and accessible language for everyone."

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/dushanbe-teen-develops-tajikistans-first-ai-legal-assistant/)

5. Turkmenistan opens door to crypto mining, keeps firm grip on exchanges

(The Times of Central Asia)

Turkmenistan has taken a rare step toward opening a tightly controlled economy by legalizing cryptocurrency mining and the operation of crypto exchanges under a new **Law** on Electronic Assets. The law came into effect on January 1, 2026, creating a state-run licensing system overseen by the Central Bank of Turkmenistan, while keeping strict limits on how crypto can be used inside the country.

The legal change, signed by President **Serdar Berdimuhamedov**, brings *"virtual assets"* under civil law, meaning that crypto is treated as property rather than money. Under the framework, cryptocurrencies are not recognized as legal tender and cannot be treated as a currency or security for domestic payments.

The law covers the creation, storage, issuance, and circulation of virtual assets. It also states that the government is not responsible for losses incurred through crypto platforms or for drops in asset value. Mining rights are available to individual entrepreneurs and corporate entities that register electronically with the central bank, and the law explicitly bans *"hidden mining"* that uses someone else's computing resources without permission.

The model combines ultra-cheap energy with a license-driven regulatory system, a structure that may attract some miners while deterring firms that depend on flexible compliance regimes or unrestricted connectivity.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/turkmenistan-opens-door-to-crypto-mining-keeps-firm-grip-on-exchanges/)

Global News

6. Malaysia and Indonesia become first to block Musk's Grok over AI deepfakes

(apnews.com)

KUALA LUMPUR, Malaysia *(AP)* – Malaysia and Indonesia have become the first countries to block Grok, the artificial intelligence chatbot developed by Elon Musk's xAI, after authorities said it was being misused to generate sexually explicit and non-consensual images.

The moves reflect growing global concern over generative AI tools that can produce realistic images, sound and text, while existing safeguards fail to prevent their abuse. The Grok chatbot, which is accessed through Musk's social media platform X, has been criticized for generating manipulated images, including depictions of women in bikinis or sexually explicit poses, as well as images involving children.

Regulators in the two Southeast Asian nations said existing controls were not preventing the creation and spread of fake pornographic content, particularly involving women and minors. Indonesia's government temporarily blocked access to Grok, followed by Malaysia.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/article/grok-malaysia-indonesia-block-c7cb320327f259c4da35908e1269c225)

7. NVIDIA Announces Alpamayo Family of Open-Source AI Models and Tools to Accelerate Safe, Reasoning-Based Autonomous Vehicle Development *(Nvidianews)*

NVIDIA has introduced the Alpamayo autonomous vehicle development platform as an open, reasoning-based AI ecosystem designed to significantly improve the safety and transparency of self-driving systems. Unlike traditional perception-focused models, Alpamayo uses advanced vision-language-action AI that allows autonomous vehicles not only to see their surroundings but also to reason about complex driving situations and explain their decisions. At the core of the release is Alpamayo-1, a large-scale chain-of-thought model capable of generating driving trajectories together with human-readable reasoning, which improves trust, validation, and regulatory readiness.

The platform is supported by open-source simulation tools and extensive real-world driving datasets that enable developers to test rare and high-risk scenarios before real-world deployment. By making these models, tools, and data openly available, NVIDIA aims to accelerate the global development of safe **Level**-4 autonomous vehicles and marks a shift toward what the company describes as a *"ChatGPT moment for physical AI,"* where reasoning becomes central to autonomous driving systems.

(Read full article at https://nvidianews.nvidia.com/news/alpamayo-autonomous-vehicle-development)

8. California Lawmaker Proposes Four-Year Ban on AI Chatbot Toys for Children

(AI insider)

California State Senator **Steve Padilla** has introduced legislation seeking a four-year ban on the sale and manufacture of toys with AI chatbot capabilities for children under 18. The bill, known as SB 867, is intended to give safety regulators time to develop protections against harmful AI interactions involving minors.

Padilla said the proposal reflects growing concern that existing safety frameworks have not kept pace with the rapid deployment of AI systems. The legislation follows recent incidents and lawsuits involving children and prolonged interactions with chatbots, as well as Padilla's earlier work co-authoring SB 243,

which mandates safeguards for chatbot operators serving children and vulnerable users.

The proposal arrives amid broader national debate over AI regulation, following a recent executive order from President **Donald Trump** directing federal agencies to challenge state AI laws, while explicitly allowing exceptions related to child safety. The bill also responds to reports of unsafe or inappropriate behavior in early AI-enabled toys and delayed product launches from major technology and consumer brands.

(Read full article at https://theaiinsider.tech/2026/01/07/california-lawmaker-proposes-four-year-ban-on-ai-chatbot-toys-for-children/)

9. Why Saudi, UAE are becoming the world's next AI heavyweights

(gulfbusiness.com)

Saudi Arabia and the UAE are currently executing a strategic pivot from being technology consumers to becoming the architects of the global AI economy. This transition is defined by a shift toward sovereign AI, where the development of digital infrastructure is driven by national priorities to ensure local ownership and data governance. Rather than relying solely on imported software, these nations are building *"heavyweight"* status by focusing on three specific frontiers: agentic AI *(systems that autonomously plan and execute tasks)*, physical AI *(industrial robotics and drones)*, and localized models optimized for the Arabic language and culture.

This ambition coincides with a global inflection point in robotics and automation. With industrial robot shipments projected to double by 2030 due to labor shortages, the Gulf is positioning itself at the center of this physical-digital convergence. Regional adoption is already outpacing Western markets; consumer usage of generative AI in Saudi Arabia and the UAE is significantly higher than in Europe, and nearly 70 % of regional organizations plan to increase investment. By 2026, the region anticipates a landscape where government manual workloads are reduced by 30 % and enterprises are run by *"mixed human-AI teams."*

However, this rapid acceleration faces a *"perfect storm"* of execution challenges. The market is entering a phase of reckoning where the hype must yield to tangible Return on Investment *(ROI).* As CFOs demand accountability for expensive

infrastructure, the region must overcome significant talent shortages and the technical risks of *"error propagation"* in autonomous systems. Consequently, the next phase of growth will be characterized less by unbridled experimentation and more by strict governance, reliability, and the integration of AI agents as accountable teammates rather than just tools.

(Read full article at https://gulfbusiness.com/why-saudi-uae-are-becoming-the-worlds-next-ai/)

10. India's Deep Tech Startup Surge: AI Investments Fuel 2026 Innovation Hubs

(academicjobs.com)

India's startup ecosystem is undergoing a fundamental transformation, shifting focus from consumer applications to deep tech sectors like artificial intelligence, semiconductors, and quantum computing. This evolution is fueled by a massive influx of capital, including $ 67.5 billion in infrastructure commitments from Big Tech giants *(such as Microsoft and Amazon)* and robust government backing via the India AI Mission and a ₹ 1 lakh crore R&D scheme. Consequently, India has secured the third spot on the Global AI Vibrancy Index, positioning itself as a key hedge against U.S.-China dominance.

By 2026, the geography of this innovation is expanding beyond traditional metros. While Bengaluru remains a top-five global AI city, the ecosystem is democratizing with significant developments in tier-2 cities and mega-projects like a $ 15 billion AI hub in Visakhapatnam. However, this rapid scaling faces critical structural challenges, primarily the acute shortage of specialized talent in niche technical fields and the urgent need for sustainable energy infrastructure to support a projected tripling of data center capacity.

(Read full article at https://www.academicjobs.com/higher-education-news/indias-deep-tech-startup-surge-massive-ai-investments-fuel-innovation-hubs-in-2026-45)

11. World's first physically growing AI-powered pocket pet unveiled at CES 2026

(apnews.com)

At CES 2026, Chinese startup Takway AI introduced a significant evolution in digital companionship with Sweekar, the world's first AI-powered **pocket pet that physically grows**. Unlike traditional virtual pets confined to screens *(such as the Tamagotchi)*, Sweekar features a mechanical design that allows it to physically expand out of its egg-like casing as it *"ages"* from an incubation stage to adulthood. This tangible experience is reinforced by sensors that simulate biological traits, such as body warmth and rhythmic breathing, to foster a deeper emotional connection with the user.

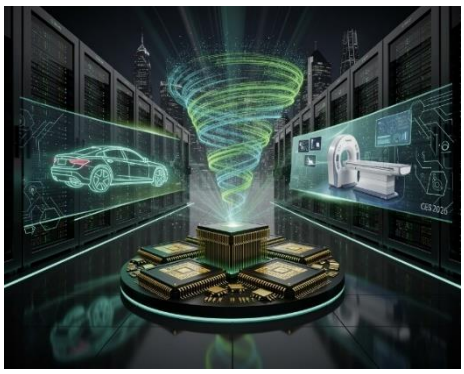
The device's core innovation lies in its *"brain,"* which utilizes a hybrid AI stack *(including Gemini Flash and ChatGPT-class models)* to support fluid voice conversation and Long-Term Memory (LTM). Instead of following pre-programmed loops, Sweekar develops a unique personality based on MBTI behavioral modeling, adapting its temperament to how the owner treats it. Crucially, the system addresses the *"anxiety"* of legacy digital pets: once Sweekar reaches adulthood, it becomes autonomous, capable of entertaining itself and going on virtual adventures without the risk of *"dying"* from neglect, thereby positioning it as a low-stress, emotionally intelligent teammate rather than a high-maintenance toy.

(Read full article at https://apnews.com/video/worlds-first-physically-growing-ai-powered-pocket-pet-unveiled-at-ces-2026-3e2146cf08724e068c700f2a1ee1cabd)

12. Nvidia unveils Rubin platform with 10x lower inference token costs

(investing.com)

At CES 2026, Nvidia officially unveiled the Rubin AI platform, a next-generation infrastructure designed to fundamentally reshape the economics of artificial intelligence. Named after astronomer Vera Rubin, the architecture succeeds the Blackwell system and is engineered to address the critical *"power wall"* facing data centers. By integrating the new Vera CPU and Rubin GPU – which features advanced HBM4 memory and NVLink 6 interconnects – the platform functions as a unified *"supercomputer"* rather than a collection of disparate parts.



The most significant impact of this launch is a projected 90 % reduction in AI inference costs. This dramatic lowering of the financial barrier is expected to catalyze widespread enterprise adoption, moving AI from expensive pilot programs to standard operational infrastructure. Major tech giants, including Microsoft and AWS, have already committed to deploying the system to support the next wave of *"Agentic AI" (autonomous software agents)* and *"Physical AI" (robotics and autonomous vehicles),* effectively positioning the Rubin platform as the backbone of the 2026 industrial AI economy.

(Read full article at https://www.investing.com/news/company-news/abbvie-and-remegen-partner-on-novel-cancer-bispecific-antibody-93CH-4441858)

ANALYSIS

13. Trump administration's vision of US tech dominance is colliding with Europe

(CNN)

Last January, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg said he was eager to have an ally in the White House to go after foreign regulations *"pushing"* American tech firms *"to censor more"* content.

That was days before Donald Trump's inauguration, and the president has been quite willing to take up that mantle. It's led to an escalating stand-off between the United States and European Union that could increasingly weigh on their relationship.

The **president** has pushed the European Union and other foreign governments to pull back on regulating US tech firms, while also promoting fewer guardrails domestically. His administration intensified those efforts last month by threatening to penalize European tech firms and seeking to block prominent tech safety researchers and a regulator from entering the United States.

The growing tensions are rooted in a fundamental disagreement over the regulation of tech companies. **Regulators** in Europe, a global leader in tech-related legislation, believe some guardrails promote online safety, free speech and industry competition. The United States has taken a largely hands-off approach.

Republicans, now controlling the US government, have in recent years framed content moderation efforts as *"censorship."* And US tech companies – chafing at having to comply with new EU requirements or face fines – may now be seizing an opportunity to push back.

It's a conflict that could put Silicon Valley in the crosshairs of wider US-EU trade negotiations this year, especially as the Trump administration views unfettered advancement in artificial intelligence as crucial for the economy and national security.

(Read full article at https://edition.cnn.com/2026/01/12/tech/us-eu-tech-regulation-fight-explained)

14. Central Asia Tech Landscape 2026: The Race for Compliance vs. Creativity

As of mid-January 2026, the tech landscape in Central Asia is undergoing a definitive split, creating a complex new reality for regional players. We are witnessing a significant bifurcation where our neighbors are adopting diametrically opposite strategies: Kazakhstan is solidifying its market maturity through rigid regulation, while Kyrgyzstan is aggressively carving out a niche in the experimental *"creator economy."* For IT Park Uzbekistan, these simultaneous shifts are not just news – they are a clear signal to define our own path as the region's *"Compliance & Enterprise Hub."*

To the north, the era of unregulated AI development has effectively ended. With Kazakhstan's *"Law on Artificial Intelligence"* coming into force on January 18, 2026, the market has shifted from a laissez-faire approach to a European-style risk model. This creates the region's first true non-tariff barrier for foreign software. The new legislation is built around mandatory transparency, requiring that all AI-generated content – text, video, or image – carry machine-readable metadata tags. For IT Park residents, this is a critical market access requirement, not merely a technical detail. The law introduces strict liability for developers, meaning an Uzbek-made model that leaks data or causes harm through *"hallucinations"* now carries legal weight for its creators, regardless of end-user intent. With high-stakes sectors like HR and healthcare now classified as *"High Risk"* and requiring state audits, there is an immediate urgency for our exporters to audit their software for compliance before attempting to sell across the border.

Simultaneously, to the east, Kyrgyzstan is moving in a completely different direction. The High Tech Park's *"Pre-Registration 2026"* campaign signals a decisive pivot away from generalist outsourcing toward the Web3 and Creative Industries. By effectively merging the concepts of *"IT"* and the *"Creative Economy,"* Kyrgyzstan is positioning itself as a tax haven for decentralized projects, offering specific legal

recognition for DAOs and aggressively courting the *"digital nomad"* demographic. They are betting on the experimental edge of tech – GameDev, the Metaverse, and NFT art.

This strategic divergence offers IT Park Uzbekistan a golden opportunity to sharpen its own identity by doing exactly what our neighbors are not. Rather than competing for the volatile crypto-nomad market or getting bogged down in regulatory hurdles without preparation, we can position Uzbekistan as the "Enterprise Stability Hub" of Central Asia. While Kyrgyzstan chases the experimental, we can double down on serious B2B infrastructure – Fintech, Logistics, and Corporate SaaS – offering the stable, regulated environment that major institutional investors crave.

Ultimately, the regional map is being redrawn, and our strategy must be dual-track. We must establish an export compliance support structure to help our residents navigate Kazakhstan's new safety standards, ensuring we don't lose that market. At the same time, we should market our stability and maturity to counter the creative hype from Bishkek. The smart play is not direct competition, but complementary integration: positioning Uzbek Fintechs as the reliable *"shovels and rails"* that support the experimental growth happening next door.

(Read full articles at EY Kazakhstan: Law on Artificial Intelligence

CWB IP: Kazakhstan Adopts First AI Law

Times of Central Asia: Future of Kyrgyz Tech

Kyrgyzstan High Tech Park)